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WHILE THE RAM MANDIR IS SEEN AS AN ACHIEVEMENT, EVEN THE BJP IS WARY OF MAKING IT THEIR WHOLE AGENDA AS INDIA ADVANCES TOWARDS LOK SABHA POLLS

will ask, what next. When the dust settles over the Mandir consecration, people will ask what did I get out of this beyond a prayer? Did I get food or a job?"

The BJP has already sensed the mood of the electorate, and more than the Mandir, will project Modi and his government's achievements in Election 2024. Union parliamentary affairs and mines minister Pralhad Joshi asserts that while Ram Mandir is an achievement, it is not the BJP's whole agenda. "The BJP's focus is on development, the leadership of the PM, the image of India, lifting over 250 million out of poverty, good governance and a corruption-free and stable government," he says. However, Professor Narender Kumar, chairperson, Centre for Political Studies, JNU, believes that India under the BJP has moved away from the secularism envisioned in the Constitution, which could have serious consequences. He says, "The minorities in India seem to have accepted things as they don't want to get involved in confrontation that could lead to physical violence." But Kumar feels the excitement over the Ram temple may not be sustainable for the BJP. "Religion cannot solve the basic issues of *roti*, *kapda* or *makaan*," he points out.

THE QUEST FOR RAM RAJYA

Kumar is right. Religion per se cannot feed an empty stomach. Nor can it be the glue that can bind a nation together and help it progress faster. India only has to look in its own backyard to see how Pakistan, which owed its very existence to religious principles, had to let go of East Bengal within two decades because of political dissonance and division. Moreover, while Ram Rajya sounds impressive as an ideal worth achieving, its definitions differ and its vague promise may leave voters dissatisfied. Amish Tripathi, a scholar and author of Indian mythology, defines Ram Rajya as a state "where all are treated as equal, where the weak are protected and where Dharma and righteousness are above all". But when the RSS experts talk of reclaiming India's cultural heritage, they talk of a time just before the Muslims and then the British subjugated India. History, however, shows the marks of internal contradictions long before these invaders took over the country, including a rigid and oppressive caste structure, blind idolatry and rituals to propitiate the gods that only a few privileged by birth were able to conduct, which had led to the decay of Hinduism. In fact, Buddhism had elbowed out Hinduism as India's prime religion for over a thousand years because it offered a less intimidating and more inclusive path to enlightenment. It was only circa 8th century CE that Shankaracharya revived India's ancient religion with remarkable success.

With the caste system still deeply entrenched and highly politicised in India, reforms remain a work in progress. The Hindu religion is also not a monotheistic entity but a composite of hundreds of deities that make the religion both inclusive and exclusive. If Nehru saw big dams as the temples of modern India, it was because he realised that culture must keep pace with technology. As an expert put it, "You can't fight Pakistan or China with bows and arrows. You need to bring the force of modern technology." To be fair, Modi has focused on pushing India to become a technologically advanced nation that is not in contradiction with Bharat's ethos. Scholars point out that spiritualism in India is seen as an individual quest to attain *moksha* or enlightenment by uniting with the divinity which is regarded as an absolute, formless, indefinable One, irrespective of the paths and deities chosen to get there. It has a far broader definition of Ekeshwar than a limiting notion of cultural unity. Meanwhile, the Ram Rajya that the RSS seeks, while a noble endeavour, is an uphill one. Hosabale acknowledges that when he says, "For such an ancient and big nation, Ram Rajya cannot happen overnight. It will take some years, perhaps even a generation, to establish it. But we are on the path towards it." The recent consecration at the Ram Mandir will certainly help fast-track that process. ■

with Kaushik Deka and Anilesh S. Mahajan